Loch Ness Monsters and Something Like Fire

By Lenelle Moise (pronounced "moy-eez")
and Tana Hardy

INTRODUCTION

Martin Niemöller, a prominent Protestant pastor who opposed the Nazi regime, who spent the last seven years of Nazi rule in a concentration camp, spoke these words of wisdom 80 years ago: .First they came for the Socialists, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a Socialist. Then they came for the Trade Unionists, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a Trade Unionist. Then they came for the Jews, and I did not speak out— Because I was not a Jew. Then they came for me—and there was no one left to speak for me. How can we turn a blind eye to man's inhumanity to man even on a small, individual scale. Lenelle Moise asks this question in her poem Loch Ness Monsters.

Loch Ness Monsters by Lenelle Moise

after patricia's face
was dragged across
the parking lot of pete's

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grocery store and gasoline
stop on buffalo street
in ithaca, ny, one late afternoon
during rush hour traffic in july
2002's brutal, blatant sun

after a white man held her down
and two white women kicked her jaw because
they claimed – although they sat innocently
in their parked pickup truck --
this stranger/black woman --
patricia – just had to go and look
at them funny so they had to get out and try
to put her in her place

after their fists and their spit
after their tired word nigger

after ithacan would-be witnesses
filled their giant grape slurpee cups – filled
their unleaded tanks – filled their ears

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with the predictable weather forecast – their ears
with an international report on terrorism --
their air-conditioned ears turned off to screams,
turned on to britney spears' overplayed number
one hit *hit me baby one more time.*

after bystanders sat
in their jammed cars, unmoved, someone
inside the grocery store
called the cops and,
late, the cops
handcuffed the assaulted
twenty-year-old black woman
first because –

though her stunned skull thumped
with bitter bewilderment and her broad
nose bled from the burden of meeting
her tears on three dog shit shoes --
since patricia was shrilling *cracker* and flailing
her bruised arms uncontrollably, the ithacan

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cops thought she seemed
menacing, not molested

after the ithaca times
reported the incident four days
late, the local liberal whites simply
could not believe
it happened here. *here?*
in Ithaca? My god,
they said, *that's just*
incredible. are you serious? here?

and i wonder how some people can keep their minds
open to the possibility of a loch ness monster
open to extraterrestrials, open
to the crazed fantasy of a so-called king of rock
and roll resurrected, somehow
sighted alive; how people will
nod *of course* to a headline that guesses
angelina stole brad from jennifer;

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tarot cards, ouija boards

tea leaves for spiritual guidance

people will bribe invisible grim reapers

with age-defying dreams and potions

people will encourage their children

to write letters to santa claus, share

secrets with jesus and keep appointments

with philanthropic tooth fairies

but the sun we can all confirm and agree upon

will shine down on one black woman –

patricia - getting her ass kicked

by three epithet-wielding whites –

her spirit and features evidently crushed

by their hate – the rage in her

gut, the insistence of her fists

obviously outnumbered

and some people just cannot

see it.

and some people just don't

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believe it.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lenelle Moise
Book: Word Warriors: 35 Women Leaders in the Spoken Word Revolution
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TRANSITION

And yet in a sea of those who turn a blind eye, those who are wronged . . . abused . . . brutalized . . . somehow survive. Tana Hardy questions how those survivors come to view the world. Do they take up the mantle of "defender of the innocent" – "voice of the down-trodden" or do they revel in the word. Survivor. Because I survived, I am better than THOSE victims. Because I survived, they should be able to as well. What does the word survivor mean to you? Something Like Fire by Tana Hardy.

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Something Like Fire by Tana Hardy

Survivor: "…but I did it because of the trauma."

Survivor- what a pointed word.
What a something to sharpen and jab
at someone. Survivor- what a blockade
to stand behind. What a shield. What a
corner around which to peek
a gun. Explosive to roll into
a party. "Everything I've said and done
is because I am a Survivor!"
When is the day we become responsible

for ourselves? For the ways our damage spills over,
onto others? I want to join a parade of: This is What
I've Done and This is Where I Did it and This is to
Whom. I want a spotlight
on their scars, not mine. I want to carry
my fault on a platter, like a cake
down a street. With the names
of the people I made into a whom

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on top. Until everyone comes out
of their houses into the square
and starts confessing, as if
our future depends on it.
(Because it does.)

I want to meet the ones who made me
a whom on the other edge of town
at the end of their cake parade. I want them to put
down their sharp sticks,
empty their cheeks of explosives, and
step out from behind the barricade. I
want them to pull their whole bodies from around the
corner and say,
"Me. I did it."
Without blinking or minimizing.
And then I want them to give me
some cake. The slice with my name
on top. But when I take a second look,
I want it to be their name. I want our names to be the

same.
(Because they are.)

And then I want to hug
about it. I want Survivor to be a name
we stop taking in vain, stop using
as excuse. Here, I'll start: I have raged
and thrown and manipulated and coerced and lied and
lied and lied
and lied
and lied. Every single time I have held up the card
"survivor" as if it is a get out of jail free ticket. But
there are real live names in my wake. In the sea foam
behind my boat. Can't you see their eyes?
The way they spin in the waves- the whites and the blues
and the browns and the hazels of them?
Those are the people I made
into a whom, people to whom I gave
a card, while showing them exactly how to stand

behind it. Survivor- what a pointed word.
What a shield, an explosive. I want the day when

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Survivor means a temporary
state, a place to pass through
but not set up a permanent, fenced-in
residence. I want survivor to mean something
like a fire of renewal after which grows a forest with as
many trees as human complexities.
I don't always want to stomp my feet
on home plate saying,
"That person. Did this. To me."
But neither do I want to stand
on the pitchers mound- hurling forward
what someone else pitched

at me. I've been getting this backwards, thinking
Survivor meant I had to toughen
up instead of melt and maybe offer myself as something
to quench.
Something to ease, to nourish and embolden. Don't get
me wrong,
I am as mad as a Volkswagen full of hornets about what's
been done to me, but that doesn't mean

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I want to let my stingers out. Not

only because the world needs all of us

to step into the light. But also because what a day, what

a triumph when Survivor means

-I am-

so much more

than what was done to me.

(Because it does.)

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Tana Hardy
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